

Columns divide a printed page into parallel streams of prose. A reader follows one stream from the top of the page to the bottom before crossing the gutter to the next column in line.

Magazines and journals use columns to control line length, and therefore pacing, on a wide sheet of paper.

Screens inherited the convention without the physical constraint. On a narrow viewport two columns squeeze line length below any comfortable reading measure for the eyes.

A repagination engine must detect the layout instead of assuming a single flow of text.

The detector compares text mass in the left and right x-ranges of every page. When both ranges carry more than fifteen percent of the page text the document refuses intake.

Detection happens before any block mapping runs.

Refusal is honest failure. A silently reordered column would mangle quotations and scramble anchors, so the calm answer is a typed reason and no library entry at all.

The reader keeps a predictable surface.